

Multiplayer Dynamic Issues in Ravenswatch

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Introduction

Designing a video game is no easy task. Even for single-player experiences, there are countless elements to consider: level design, difficulty and progression curves, narrative pacing... Designing a multiplayer experience can prove to be an even greater challenge, adding extra layers on top of the aforementioned: social dynamics, communication tools, and less control over player behavior the more people involved. Designing a game that works equally well for single player and multiplayer, without breaking the game experience is extremely difficult, and when it is not executed correctly, it can lead to frustration rather than engagement, even when the core of the game is functional.

This essay examines the case of *Ravenwatch* (Passetch Games, 2024), an action roguelite where players embody some of the most iconic characters from fairy tales and fight against an evil force, the Nightmare, threatening to destroy their realm. The essay will analyze how the cooperative aspect of the game can lead to competitive behaviors among players, and explore whether this type of multiplayer experiences can work when it goes against the fundamental nature of the genre.

Ravenwatch was chosen for this analysis because it is a clear example of a game that advertises multiplayer as a core experience, when the nature of the game is inherently individualistic. As a result, the multiplayer mode is just several simultaneous individual single-player runs. This clash between multiplayer features and the genre creates an experience that is more frustrating and less engaging in multiplayer than when played alone.

For the purpose of this essay, the focus will not be on the single-player mode, but on analyzing the competitive and cooperative dynamics of the multiplayer mode, determining the root of its problems and proposing solutions by looking at similar titles within the same genre. As the primary reference, various elements of *Ravenwatch* will be compared to *Elden Ring Nightreign* (FromSoftware, 2025)

Development

The main issue that arises with *Ravenwatch* multiplayer is related to its core game design. The base structure of the game, as already mentioned, belongs to the roguelite genre. In it, players select one of several characters, each with a unique set of abilities and a different playstyle. Once inside a run, objectives are generated procedurally across the map, and the player must visit these points of interest to obtain upgrades and rewards to improve their character and face greater obstacles. The player has a limited amount of time to do this, as after 18 minutes the boss of that area appears and the player will be forced to fight it, so they must visit as many points of interest as possible before this fight in order to be as prepared as possible. This loop repeats three times throughout a run, in which the player explores, defeats enemies and obtains upgrades before facing their next objective. It is worth noting that each cycle is more difficult than the previous one, and if you do not obtain enough upgrades in the previous area, the next will be considerably harder, as the player carries a compounding deficit of upgrades and therefore power. If the player is defeated in combat, they can be revived a number of times; if these run out, the run ends and the player must start from the beginning.

Now that the game loop is clear, we can talk about the multiplayer. In multiplayer mode, up to four players can participate in a single run. Each selects a different character, with a completely unique playstyle independent from the rest. During the session, each player must obtain upgrades independently, travelling to the location where the point of interest was completed. There is no interaction between the different characters' abilities, which means that combat, despite being team-based, is completely individualistic, no coordination is required to perform combos or team actions, and therefore there is no clear shared strategy. The result is not a cooperative experience but rather several simultaneous solo runs happening at the same time. The only resource shared between players is the pool of lives: if a player is defeated in combat, one life is consumed from the team's total; if they run out, the run ends. This shared and limited resource can lead to negative dynamics within the group, generating frustration and causing players to point out each other's mistakes, creating a negative atmosphere that can lead to feelings of guilt and blame. Another problem that arises is the lack of mobility in the game, as the only way to move from one place to another is on foot, which means that characters without any movement ability spend a large portion of their time simply walking to these areas.

This gameplay isolation, combined with the multiplayer enemy scaling system, is a constant source of frustration. In multiplayer mode, enemy health scales dramatically to compensate for the presence of several players, which means that common enemies, which you can eliminate in a matter of seconds in single-player, become a threat that will cost a lone player a disproportionately long and difficult encounter, not mechanically, but due to the health and damage of these enemies. This scaling forces players to move in groups in order to compensate for the damage output needed to eliminate these enemies and progress at a reasonable pace, meaning that players in multiplayer must move through the map as if they were a single player.

The following data is taken from the *Ravenwatch Wiki (2024)* and shows enemy scaling per additional player:

The number of additional enemies added is increased by +13%

Standard Enemies' health points are increased by +30%

Elite Enemies' health points are increased by +60%

Standard Enemies' Stagger is increased by +30/40/50% (Chapter 1/2/3)

Elite Enemies' Stagger is increased by +60/70/80/90% (Chapter 1/2/3/Epilogue)

This kind of group progression gives rise to another problem: the map of *Ravenwatch* is very large and filled with objectives that, as already mentioned, must be completed in order to obtain upgrades and other rewards. The more objectives you manage to complete within the 18 minutes, the better prepared the player will be to face the boss and the next area of the game.

The problem is as follows: in order to complete all objectives and reach a sufficient level to defeat the boss without too much difficulty, players must split up and tackle different objectives in different areas of the map simultaneously. However, as discussed, the enemy scaling punishes players who go alone, making the challenge extremely difficult, as each player lacks the power to deal with scaled enemies efficiently on their own. This leaves players in a contradiction when planning their sessions: the map requires them to separate in order to complete as many objectives as possible, but the combat system punishes them for doing so. This problem has no solution within the current design, making the multiplayer experience considerably slower, more tedious, and far more punishing of individual mistakes than a single-player run.

Having analyzed the scaling system, the reward system can now be examined in more detail. It is important to note that exploration is a core element of the gameplay. Not all objectives are visible from the start; they are revealed as players discover them by moving through the map. When a player discovers a valuable upgrade on their side of the map, the other players must travel to that location to collect it. In a game where time is a limited resource and the map is large, moving from one area to another carries a heavy cost, penalizing the very core mechanic already mentioned: exploration. For example, if a player finds an upgrade on the left edge of the map while their companion is exploring objectives in the south, the latter must decide whether to abandon their area and move north to claim the rewards, or continue exploring locally and forgo those rewards, since enemy scaling makes lone traversal a dangerous task. This system discourages the kind of efficient, distributed play for which the map is designed, creating a persistent sense of frustration as players find themselves unable to collect all available rewards and consequently fall behind in level.

These dynamics scale poorly with player count. With two players, the experience is strained but manageable, closely resembling a single-player run in which players are occasionally forced to regroup for certain objectives. With three to four players, the difficulty increases significantly.

Enemy scaling becomes more extreme and the coordination required to plan routes and complete objectives is greater, but the absence of in-game communication tools means that disorganization and lack of forward planning take a heavy toll. Mistakes such as a player dying unexpectedly in an encounter, they were not ready for, or a life being consumed due to a poorly coordinated action, become much more frequent and cause individual errors to affect the entire group negatively.

These problems arise primarily from three design failures: an enemy scaling system not designed with player separation in mind, a reward distribution system that penalizes group movement and map exploration, and the absence of communication tools within the game.

Starting with the enemy scaling system, it appears to have been balanced under the assumption that players would remain grouped throughout the run, scaling enemy values proportionally to player count in order to balance the total damage output all players could collectively deal to a single target, without taking into account how this affects the rest of the game's systems, such as the map design itself and the distribution of points of interest. By only scaling enemy values with player count, without providing players with any means to deal with those enemies individually, the system creates a contradiction it cannot resolve.

The reward system suffers from the same fundamental problem: a lack of consideration for the dynamics specific to the multiplayer experience. In a single-player run, the player always collects rewards from the areas they explore as they find them, with no need to travel from one part of the map to another, maximizing their exploration efficiency. In multiplayer, applying the same dynamic without accounting for the cost that travelling across the map imposes on players, sacrificing the exploration of other areas to collect rewards, means players can never be as efficient as in a solo run. The absence of reward-sharing mechanics or fast travel options suggests that the multiplayer mode was built on top of the single-player framework without sufficiently reconsidering the problems this would create.

As for the communication tools available in multiplayer, these are limited to a map marker that allows players to flag a single location on the map. While this tool can prove to be useful as an immediate form of communication, indicating where one intends to go next, it does not support route planning or long-term coordination between players, limiting the strategic layers of the game, which, taking into account the difficulty of the multiplayer, are necessary. In order to coordinate effectively, players must rely on external applications outside the game itself, such as *Discord*.

Elden Ring Nightreign is an action roguelite designed from the outset to be played in multiplayer, and as such presents a holistic approach to the interaction between all of its systems and between its players. As in *Ravenswatch*, players must traverse a large map filled with objectives that must be completed before the boss fight, improving their character individually along the way. A run is also divided into 3 loops. The close structural similarity between the core loops of both games makes *Nightreign* an ideal reference for finding solutions to the problems detected in *Ravenswatch*.

The most significant change in *Nightreign's* approach to multiplayer can be seen in the enemy scaling system. Rather than scaling common enemies depending on the number of players, *Nightreign* opts to reserve difficulty increases for bosses and high-value targets. Common enemies are the same whether one or four players are present, which means that players can split up and cover different areas of the map without any immediate threat making solo traversal unmanageable. The scaling applied to bosses naturally draws players together to defeat the most powerful enemies, incentivizing planning and teamwork at specific, meaningful moments of the session. This design approach encourages both exploration and teamwork without penalizing either playstyle.

Nightreign also addresses the problem of individualistic gameplay by introducing character synergies. Certain character combinations produce interactions between their mechanics that allow players to deal greater damage or paralyze enemies, making the most of each character's individual mechanics and rewarding coordination between players. For example, Wylder's ultimate ability sets off an explosion that stuns the enemy, leaving a trail of fire behind. This can be combined with the Recluse's ability to absorb elements, allowing her to charge her abilities from his fire damage. While there are specific interactions that favor combinations between certain characters, the game introduces ways for players to collaborate during combat to favor teamwork: when one player staggers an enemy, allies can take the opening and perform a strong attack dealing great damage. Some enemy attack animations can be cancelled by attacking them, so players can cover each other by attacking an enemy about to strike an ally, among many other interactions. These synergies create a consistent incentive for players to work together and time their abilities to exploit the different mechanics and interactions. *Ravenswatch* characters, by contrast, are very individualistic, with no equivalent system to encourage coordination or teamwork.

The reward distribution problem is also solved in several ways: players move at high speed when out of combat, which facilitates movement across the map. There are also fast travel points distributed throughout the map that take you from one side to the other quickly, allowing players to cross from one end of the map to the other in a short time. Experience gained from defeating enemies is shared, so players can split up and defeat enemies in different areas of the map while still contributing proactively to the team, although it is necessary for players to regroup and work together to defeat bosses and other powerful enemies on the map. The rewards obtained from these fights are substantially better than any others, and since they require players to be together to face the challenge, they ensure that everyone receives the reward at the end of the encounter. *Nightreign* also resolves the negative dynamics and conflict that arose from the life system. Here there is no limited life pool: if a player is downed in combat, they remain on the ground for a few seconds and allies can strike them a set number of times, scaling with how many times that player has already been downed, up to a maximum of 3, to revive them. If a player dies completely, they remain in the run but lose a level and must return to the location where they died to recover the lost experience, allowing players to recover from their mistakes. This system not only minimizes the frustration of being defeated and reduces the weight of individual errors but reinforces

teamwork and player interaction by allowing allies to compensate for a teammate's mistake by reviving them, creating a positive interaction dynamic between players, where collaborating provides more value than an individualistic playstyle.

Finally, despite sharing the same map marker system as *Ravenswatch*, *Nightreign* addresses its limitations with a simple adjustment: players can place up to three markers simultaneously, numbered one to three in the order they are placed. This allows teammates to see each other's future intentions and plan actions over a much longer time horizon, coordinating exploration and encounters to regroup more effectively.

Conclusion

The problems identified in *Ravenswatch* are the result of a lack of game design consideration for multiplayer. Other roguelites that have added multiplayer to their experience have encountered the same problems, due to the inherently individualistic nature of the genre. *The Binding of Isaac: Repentance's* multiplayer mode has been similarly criticized for feeling like parallel solo play rather than genuine cooperation.

The solution proposed in this essay consists of redesigning the core elements of a game to adapt them to the new requirements of the multiplayer mode. This includes scaling enemy difficulty by level, introducing character synergies and player interaction dynamics, providing players with the necessary communication tools, and avoiding mechanics that do not favor cooperation, such as individually gated upgrades that cause some players to fall behind while others pull ahead, turning what teamwork should be into competition. When the systems of a game are built to reward a solo playstyle, multiplayer becomes a superficial feature that adds nothing to the game experience.

If the proposed changes were implemented, the multiplayer experience of *Ravenswatch* could be reshaped to be less frustrating and more genuinely cooperative: scaling only bosses and specific enemies, combined with improvements to mobility and shared experience, would reinforce exploration and the ability of players to obtain upgrades and face greater challenges. Improved communication tools would help players coordinate their exploration and maximize resource acquisition, and the removal of the shared death limit would eliminate negative dynamics, favoring collaboration over competition to see who can power up faster, since player progression would be far more balanced, giving more experienced players the opportunity to continue supporting their teammates even when they fall in combat.

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